



THE MANDATE OF HEAVEN

ZHOU DYNASTY CHINA (c. 1046 BCE–256 BCE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The right to rule

BEFORE

c. 1600–c. 1046 BCE The Shang, the first Chinese dynasty, rules over much of eastern China. Shang kings create the first Chinese laws. Crimes are punished with the death penalty, mutilation, or imprisonment with hard labor.

AFTER

770–476 BCE Zhou dynastic power is weakened as local rulers compete for supremacy.

476–221 BCE Zhou China breaks up into seven warring states, but Zhou kings continue to play a ritual role until the final king, Nan, is deposed in 256 BCE.

221 BCE The Qin state triumphs, and China is united by Qin Shi Huang, the first emperor of the Qin dynasty.

Around 1046 BCE, King Wu of the state of Zhou overthrew the last king of the Shang dynasty, which had governed China for five centuries. To justify his rebellion, the founder of the new Zhou dynasty appealed to a concept called *tianming* (“Mandate of Heaven”). Wu argued that a king could only govern if he was favored by heaven. He said that Shang kings had neglected their sacred duties and ruled corruptly, so heaven would transfer its mandate to another dynasty.

Shang kings had derived their royal authority from their supposed ability to communicate with their ancestors through divination. They did this by interpreting cracks made in bones and turtle shells. King Wu and the rulers who succeeded him, including those of later dynasties, now used the Mandate of Heaven to justify their rule.

The duty of kings

Zhou kings believed that they had a duty to rule justly or they risked losing heaven’s mandate. This duty

is described in the earliest Zhou documents. In the *Kang Gao* (*Announcement to the Prince of Kang*), attributed to Wu, the king gives legal advice to Feng, his younger brother. Feng had been appointed to govern a region of Zhou territory. Wu warns his brother not to let punishments “be warped to agree with [your] own inclinations” and tells him to revere the laws. ■



The Mandate is not easy to keep; may it not end in your persons. Display and make bright your good fame ...

Ode on King Wen

King Wen (1152–1056 BCE) was King Wu's father



See also: Early legal codes 18–19 ■ Confucianism, Daoism, and Legalism 26–29 ■ Magna Carta 66–71 ■ The trial of Charles I 96–97